

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into a quiet room.

A kettle not long boiled. On the side table, two mugs. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it. It has sat there a while.

MAYA, 30s, on the sofa in her coat, a book face down on her knee. JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, moving without hurry, at home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him eases. A body deciding it isn't alone.

JAMES

There was a heron on the tarn this morning. Same spot as yesterday.

MAYA

Mm.

JAMES

Just stood there. Hours, probably.

MAYA

You said we'd talk when we got here. Three hours in the car. That was the deal.

JAMES

We're talking.

MAYA

You're telling me about a bird.

He rinses a third mug. Dries it. Puts it away. The two on the table he doesn't touch.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Come and sit down. Please.

JAMES
Two secs.

He wipes the counter. It is already clean. He wipes it again.

MAYA
You've done that twice.

JAMES
It's a rental.

She lets it go. Doesn't let it go.

MAYA
You talked about that heron for ten minutes in the car. I counted. Ten minutes. A bird, standing.

JAMES
You asked what I did yesterday.

MAYA
I did. Fair. I did ask.

Her eyes go to the cold mug, the skin on it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
That's been there since this morning.

JAMES
I'll get it.

He doesn't. He comes through, finally, and sits. The armchair. Not the sofa. The small distance lands on her.

He settles in. Then, quiet, barely there, to the empty end of the sofa nearest him, with the ghost of a smile:

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
Shove up.

She goes still.

MAYA
What.

JAMES

Nothing.

MAYA

You said shove up.

JAMES

I didn't say anything.

She looks at the empty cushion. The one he said it to.

MAYA

(quiet)

There's no one there.

JAMES

I know there's no one there.

MAYA

Do you.

He rubs his face. Half a second where he isn't sure. Then it passes and he's only tired.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I booked this place thinking, I don't know. That different walls would give me a different you.

JAMES

I'm right here.

MAYA

You keep saying that.

A small silence. And he drifts. His attention goes off to the side of the room, away from her, and a stillness comes over him. Almost peaceful. She watches it happen, and it frightens her more than anything he could say.

She stands. Can't sit with it. Goes to the window and, for something to do with her hands, works the latch. A cold seam of air. She shuts it harder than she means to.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES

(not moving)

Here we go.

MAYA

And the second one you made sweet. Two sugars. You don't take sugar.

Silence.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Fifteen years I've known you. You
stood at that counter and put two
sugars in a cup and stirred it and
set it down, and I watched you do
it, and I didn't say a word,
because what is there to even...

She doesn't finish.

JAMES
I wasn't thinking.

MAYA
You were, though. That's the thing.
You got it exactly right. For
someone who isn't...

Neither of them says it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Is it a person.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
Just tell me if it's a person. I
could stand a person. Give me a
name, I'll go round there, I'll
have it out with her, I would
honestly rather that than--

JAMES
It's not a person.

MAYA
Then what is it.

JAMES
(tired, not kind)
You think I've the energy for an
affair.

MAYA
No. And that's worse. Do you
understand that that's worse.

She crosses. Takes his face in both her hands. Turns it to
hers.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Am I here. Look at me and tell me

I'm here.

He looks. And for a second he is all there, completely, and it is terrible how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes go. Past her. To nothing. She feels his face pull toward it under her palms.

She lets go.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You leave your own eyes. Nobody warns you that's a thing a person can do. You'll be looking right at me and you just go. Out the back of your own face.

JAMES

(quiet)

I know. You've said.

That stops her cold. He's right. She has. They have been here before.

Then, too tired to hold it:

MAYA

I'm so tired. I am so tired of living with a headstone.

Out before she can catch it. Too far, and she hears it land.

MAYA (CONT'D)

That's not what I--

JAMES

No. Say it. You've been thinking it.

MAYA

I haven't.

JAMES

You have. It's alright.

The "it's alright" is the cruellest thing in the room, and neither of them could tell you why.

She stops fighting. What's left is quiet, and it costs her.

MAYA

You could put it down. You know you could. Any of it. Just for tonight, you could--

JAMES
It isn't that simple.

MAYA
I'm not asking you to forget her.
God. I'm not asking you to...

She loses the thread. Finds a smaller, truer one.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Put it down for one minute and pick
me up. That's all. That's the whole
of what I'm asking.

JAMES
(barely)
I can't.

MAYA
You won't.

JAMES
(and he means it)
I can't, Maya.

He has no words left. So he does the other thing. He crosses to her and reaches for her, and it lands wrong, and it turns into a collision. She pushes him off, then doesn't, then takes a fistful of his shirt and pulls him back in. Messy. Teeth. Two people who know each other's bodies and nothing else that's any use tonight.

For a moment it might be an answer.

Then she feels it. His breath at her shoulder, and his face turned away. She opens her eyes.

He is looking past her. Over her shoulder. At the room. Holding her, and gone.

She shoves him off.

MAYA
You're not even...
(it won't come)
Even now. Even in the middle of
that.

He doesn't deny it. He is still half-turned toward the space.

JAMES
(almost to himself, to
it, unsure)
I don't know if you're even...

He can't finish. He doesn't know who he's asking, or whether there is anyone to ask.

He steps back. Drifts to the window and opens it again without knowing he's done it. Cold pours in.

MAYA
You've opened it again.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the empty air beside him. Palm open. At a height. For a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. What he is doing. His own hand. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The open window. Maya. Himself. The empty end of the sofa. The whole shape of it, all at once.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and breaks.

MAYA
(flinching back)
James.

He isn't looking at her. He is looking at the air. He backs away from it, and it comes after him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(pleading, to no one she
can see)
Not now. Not tonight. Go on.
Please. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

JAMES
(a roar, torn out of him,
at nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. Back, hard, away from him, across the room,

over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing. The gold window shrinking below.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high over the roof. Looks down.

At the small lit cottage. At the one warm window. At the man inside it, tiny now, both hands over his face.

And Maya behind him. Not going to him. Watching the man she loves shake at an empty room, a broken cup at his feet, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look at a place you have just been put out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.